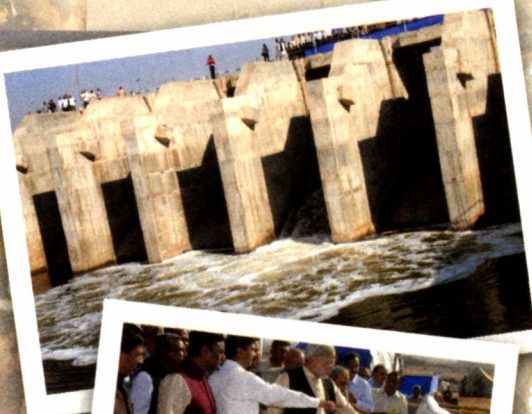


Gujarat crafts green vision for Saurashtra



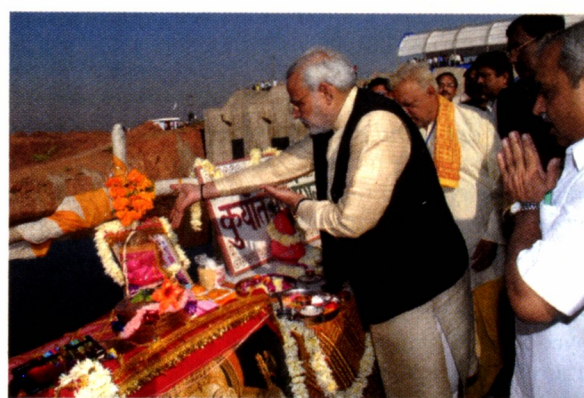
Gujarat witnesses another historic moment as Chief Minister Narendra Modi dedicates Dholi-Dhaja dam to people of Saurashtra heralding "Jal-Kranti"

It was a great moment and relief for the people of Saurashtra-Kutch region as Narmada waters began flowing into Dholi-Dhaja dam on November 29, 2009. Indeed a memorable moment to cherish when Chief Minister Narendra Modi dedicated the project worth Rs 535 crores thus scripting another historic event in the long list of Gujarat's progress. The success of Dholi-Dhaja dam came about following firm resolve of the chief minister to mitigate the hardship of the people of the region who have been suffering for decades from acute drinking water shortage. The project was completed in time bound manner and opens new vistas of progress in this region. Five giant pumping stations, said to be worlds biggest, lift Narmada waters to a height of 71 meters that flow into Dholi-Dhaja dam. These pumps located at five different places were inaugurated by Narendra Modi in 2007. In all there are 26 pumps with a capacity of 5 cusec each that would distribute waters through the Narmada canal into the Dholi-Dhaja dam. This dam will quench the thirst of 9 talukas, 11 cities and 651 villages of Surendranagar district.

On the historic occasion of inauguration ceremony, Narendra Modi was there to join in the joyous welcome as Narmada waters flowed into Dholi-Dhaja dam. This achievement ranks among the three important milestones which the state can justly be proud of. The first is the construction of the Narmada

dam followed by Narmada canals. What is sure to follow is transformation of lives as the locals have been prone to extreme drudgery and exhaustion walking mile after mile daily to fetch a pot of drinking water. The potable water now at hand

is sure to improve the health of the people and women can now devote more attention to their families and household chores even spending time tutoring their children. And most



importantly the cropping patterns are set to change leading to improved yields and faster income generation.

Earlier, crores were spent to provide irrigation facilities in 2.5 Lakh hectares of parched Saurashtra. Today the irrigation facility has doubled with the capacity to irrigate more than 5 lakh hectares and this is truly a remarkable achievement. Since last one year Narmada-based irrigation has yielded optimal results with farmers getting higher remunerative prices for cotton crop that has gone up from Rs 3,000 to Rs 5,000 per quintal. With this triumph of Dholi-Dhaja dam engineering Shri Narendra Modi has made a fervent appeal to farmers to switch over to drip irrigation.

Chief minister has also asked engineering colleges to arrange student tours to Dholi-Dhaja dam to study its marvelous engineering which has made possible bringing Narmada waters to the people. He also made a thoughtful suggestion: "Dholi-Dhaja dam could offer avenues for developing water sports." In the current year of India's 60th Republic Day, the state is planting 60,000 saplings and building "terrace-talavadis" on Public-Private Partnerships or PPP model in the hilly regions of Chotilla Tirth, he said.

For Narendra Modi government bringing Narmada waters into Dholi-Dhaja dam has been reaffirmation of its commitment to further the welfare of the state.

